NINJAS STEM FOUNDATION

Code of Conduct

POLICY ID NSF-CC-01 | STATUS Proposed for Board approval | EFFECTIVE DATE _____

1. Purpose and Scope

Ninjas STEM Foundation is committed to providing a safe, respectful, educational, and collaborative environment.

This Code establishes conduct expectations for students, parents, guardians, directors, officers, committee members, coaches, mentors, volunteers, and other participants in Foundation activities.

These expectations apply to in-person activities and program-related electronic communications.

2. Fundamental Expectations

All participants shall:

1. Treat others with dignity and respect.
2. Place student safety and learning ahead of competition results.
3. Communicate accurately, responsibly, and constructively.
4. Respect the responsibilities and delegated authority of others.
5. Follow applicable safety and competition requirements.
6. Demonstrate integrity, accountability, and good sportsmanship.
7. Protect Foundation property and information.
8. Raise concerns through appropriate channels without retaliation.

Disagreement is permitted. Personal abuse, intimidation, harassment, and deliberate interference with safe educational activities are not.

3. Student Conduct

Students are expected to participate responsibly, respect teammates and mentors, follow safety instructions, and contribute meaningfully to the team's educational work.

Students shall take responsibility for their own assignments and explain their work, ideas, and decisions.

Bullying, harassment, intentional equipment damage, academic dishonesty, and unsafe conduct are prohibited.

Mistakes, unsuccessful designs, and reasonable differences of opinion are part of learning and shall not automatically be treated as misconduct.

4. Student-Centered Learning and Competition Integrity

Students shall perform and understand the competition work assigned to them, subject to applicable competition rules.

Coaches and mentors may teach, demonstrate general techniques, provide feedback, and support independent problem-solving.

Adults shall not improperly replace students in making competition decisions or completing student-owned work.

Students shall accurately identify material external assistance and sources when required by competition rules.

Use of generative AI or externally obtained designs, information, or code shall comply with the current applicable competition policy and the Foundation's educational instructions.

The Foundation shall not assume that source acknowledgment alone cures prohibited assistance.

5. Expectations for Parents and Guardians

Parents and guardians are encouraged to support their students' learning, attendance, preparation, and responsible participation.

Parents shall respect the instructional responsibilities delegated to coaches and shall raise concerns about assignments directly with the responsible adult.

Where adults disagree over an educational assignment, they should resolve the matter between themselves or seek review through the appropriate Foundation channel.

Students should not be placed in the position of receiving unresolved contradictory adult instructions.

Parental involvement shall not substitute for the student's own work or create preferential rights to particular student roles.

6. Coaches, Mentors, Officers, and Committee Members

Adults shall exercise only the authority actually assigned to their roles.

Coaches supervise educational work within their delegated responsibilities. Organizational officers and committees carry out their approved functions. The Board retains the corporate authority established under the governing documents.

No individual shall claim broader authority merely because of volunteer service, donations, professional experience, or family involvement.

Adults shall model respectful disagreement, avoid humiliation or inappropriate pressure, and protect student welfare.

Official documents and public representations shall be accurate and appropriately reviewed before external use.

7. Board Conduct and Governance Disagreements

Directors shall participate in governance in good faith and with appropriate attention to the Foundation's interests.

Directors may question decisions, request records where entitled, express disagreement, propose amendments, and pursue lawful complaints or legal remedies.

These activities do not themselves constitute misconduct.

Board participants shall also observe reasonable meeting procedures, permit others to speak, avoid personal insults, and distinguish factual allegations from established findings.

Meeting procedures shall be applied evenhandedly and shall not be used to suppress legitimate disagreement or bypass director rights.

Removal of a director or officer remains subject to the separate governing procedures applicable to that position.

8. Financial and Organizational Integrity

Foundation funds, equipment, accounts, materials, and other resources shall be used only under proper authorization.

Participants shall disclose relevant conflicts, preserve accurate records, and avoid unauthorized commitments or representations on behalf of NSF.

No student or family shall receive special participation privileges solely in exchange for donations, fundraising, or parental organizational positions.

9. Confidentiality, Communications, and Media

Participants shall protect student records, private contact information, health information, and other appropriately restricted information.

Business communications and documents shall be retained under the applicable records policy.

No one may publish identifiable student media on behalf of NSF without the required permission and publication authorization.

No adult may engage in prohibited private communications with minors.

10. Concerns, Reporting, and Non-Retaliation

Concerns may be submitted to the designated program leader, Secretary, or another authorized unconflicted recipient when the usual recipient is involved.

Immediate safety concerns and legally reportable matters shall be handled under the Youth Protection & Safety Policy.

Good-faith concerns and lawful external reports shall not be grounds for retaliation.

A report that cannot be substantiated is not, merely for that reason, a knowingly false report.

11. Review and Corrective Action

The Foundation shall address alleged violations according to their seriousness and available evidence.

Ordinary concerns may be addressed through discussion, instruction, warnings, or appropriate corrective action.

Material adverse action should include notice of the specific concern and a reasonable opportunity to respond, except for temporary protective restrictions warranted by an immediate safety concern.

The authority and procedure for changing a student assignment, terminating enrollment, removing an officer, replacing a committee member, or removing a director are separate.

No Code provision independently grants a person authority to take an action reserved by the Bylaws or applicable law.

12. Acknowledgment and Implementation

Students and adults participating in ongoing programs shall be provided this Code and any role-specific requirements.

The Foundation may require an appropriate acknowledgment as part of onboarding.

This Code applies prospectively and shall be reviewed periodically by the Board.